Is United States, Not Texas.

Design boolean logic conditions (AND/OR/NOT) into the Advanced search filters of a people intelligence platform.

Background: Altrata is a people and wealth intelligence platform. Executive search firms use it to find candidates, fundraisers use it to find donors, and researchers use it to understand who knows whom. Advanced search is the engine underneath all of that.

Problem: Imagine looking for CEOs in the US but not Texas, who gave $50k to education but not to Harvard. A normal question for a fundraiser, and unbuildable in the product. AND/OR/NOT existed only on a handful of filters.
Three of the four legacy brands being consolidated into Altrata had a version of boolean search, built badly. Users wouldn't migrate without it.
The ticket scoped boolean to location filters only. I pushed for solving it across all of them, and executed it.

Impact: Shipped. Two rounds of testing with 18 participants established keyword search as the thing people actually use. The first release was built around it, and we're tracking adoption now.

Users	Company	Team	What I did	Duration
Researchers, fundraisers and account managers across financial services, educational institutions and nonprofits.	Altrata, London	Senior Designer (me) Junior Designer Product Owner Project Manager	Scoping Team Direction Research Concept Design Usability testing Dev handoff	3 weeks

PROCESS

The Problem's Problem
Zooming out

Two requirements arrived with almost the same need. **One was urgent** and **small, one larger** and **scheduled for later.** A quick win would hit parity fast, but guarantee a revision loop for everything else. **Double the work, double the time.**

1. Boolean logic in ***Location filters only***

2. Boolean logic in Location filters ***+ all other filters***

I made the case for solving it once, properly. What moved the PM was pointing out that a quick fix now meant doing the whole thing again in six months. The scope changed. **Solve for tomorrow, and today solves itself.**

Design Approach

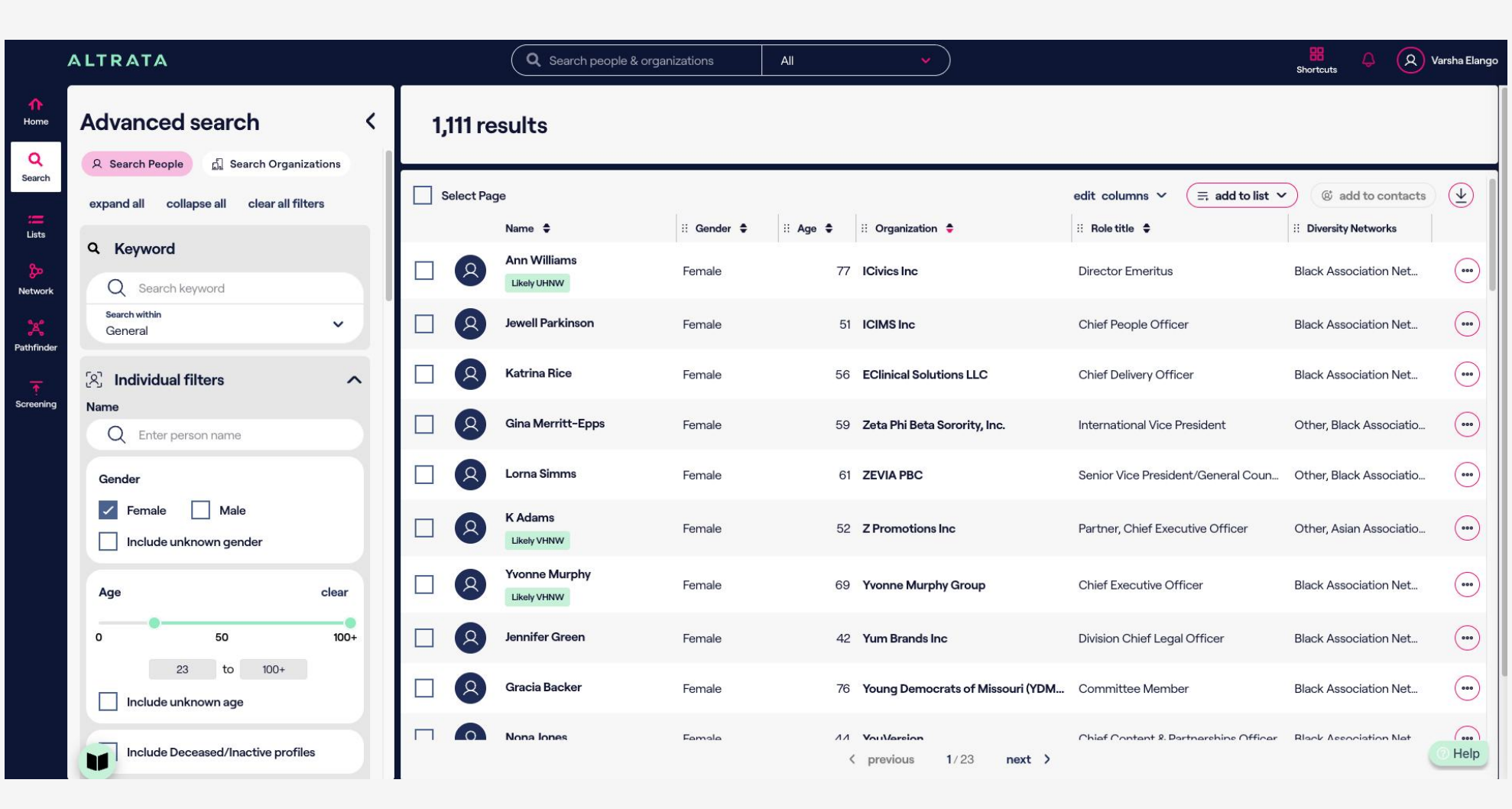
I set out a clear approach for my team to proceed with.

Ticket → Define the bigger scope → Research → Design → Test concepts with users → Synthesise → Build

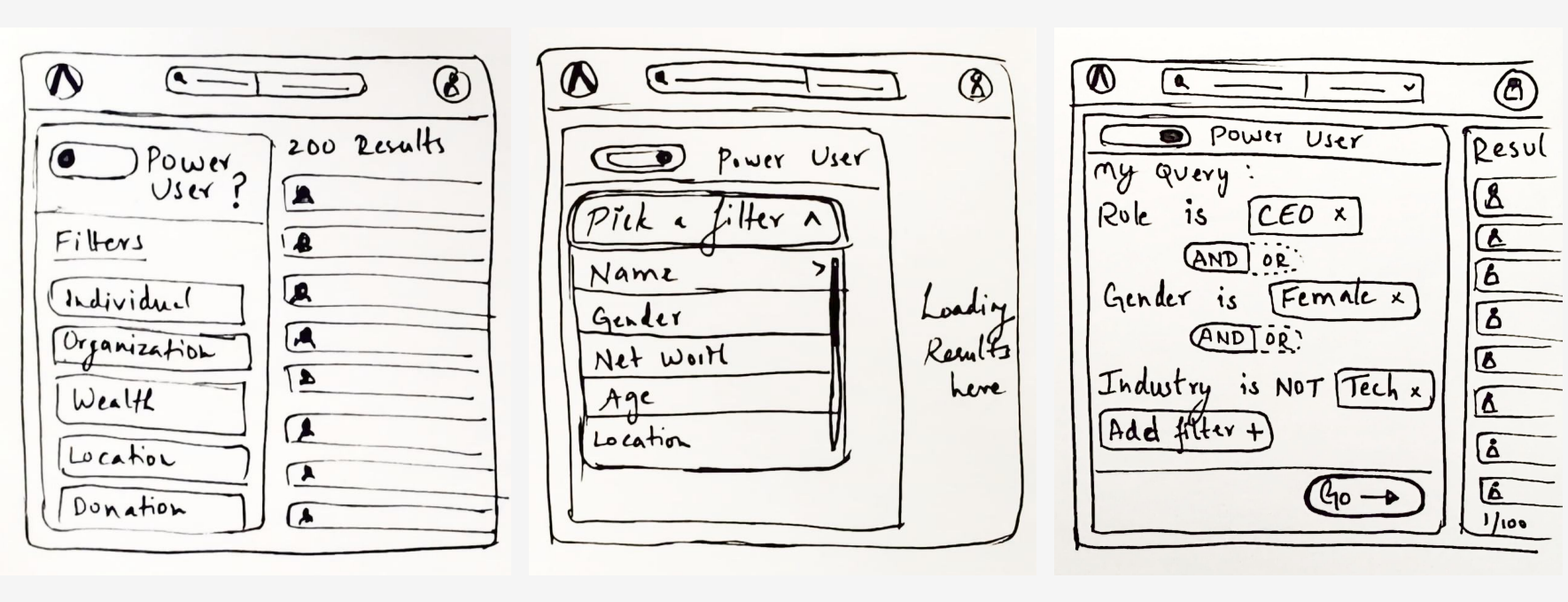
Research + Conceptualisation

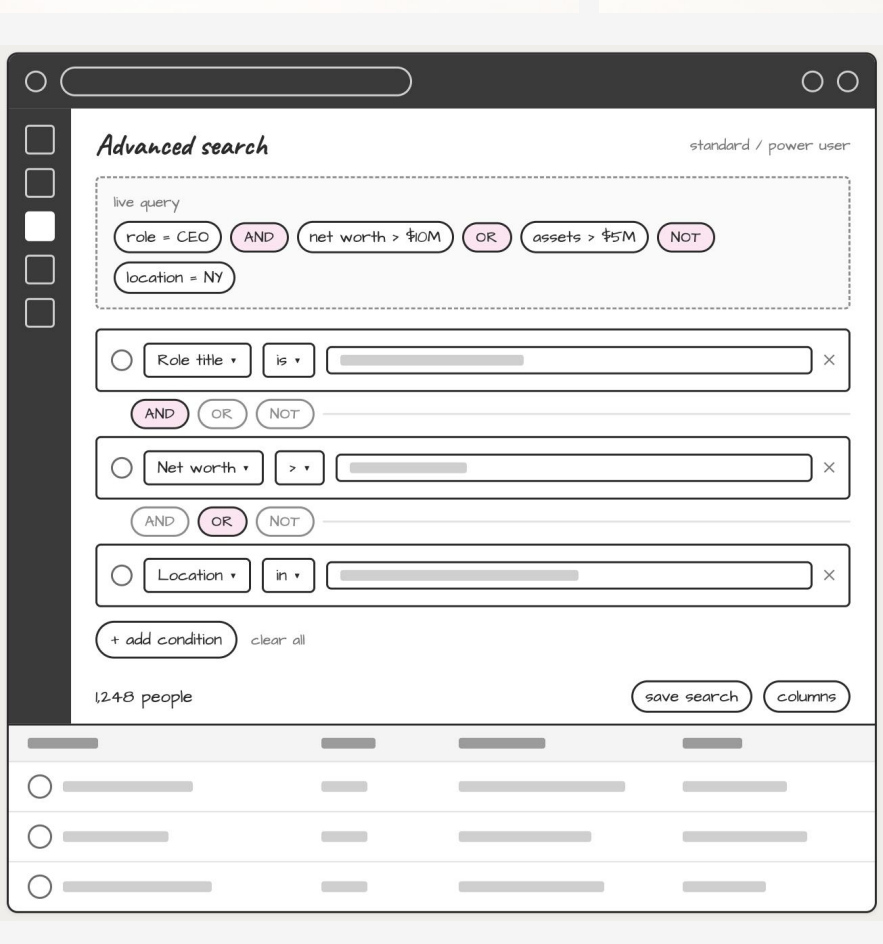
We started from **past session recordings** of clients using advanced search, alongside **secondary research** into how boolean logic actually works. Boolean had to sit above the launched feature, and designing inside that structure looked like it **would force compromises.**

Rather than assume that, **I split the exploration deliberately.** I directed my designer to work boolean into the existing advanced search, and took the opposite brief myself: question the current approach and **design from a new perspective.** Testing could then tell us whether something better existed.
I drew variations and used **Claude** to translate them into low-fi wireframes.

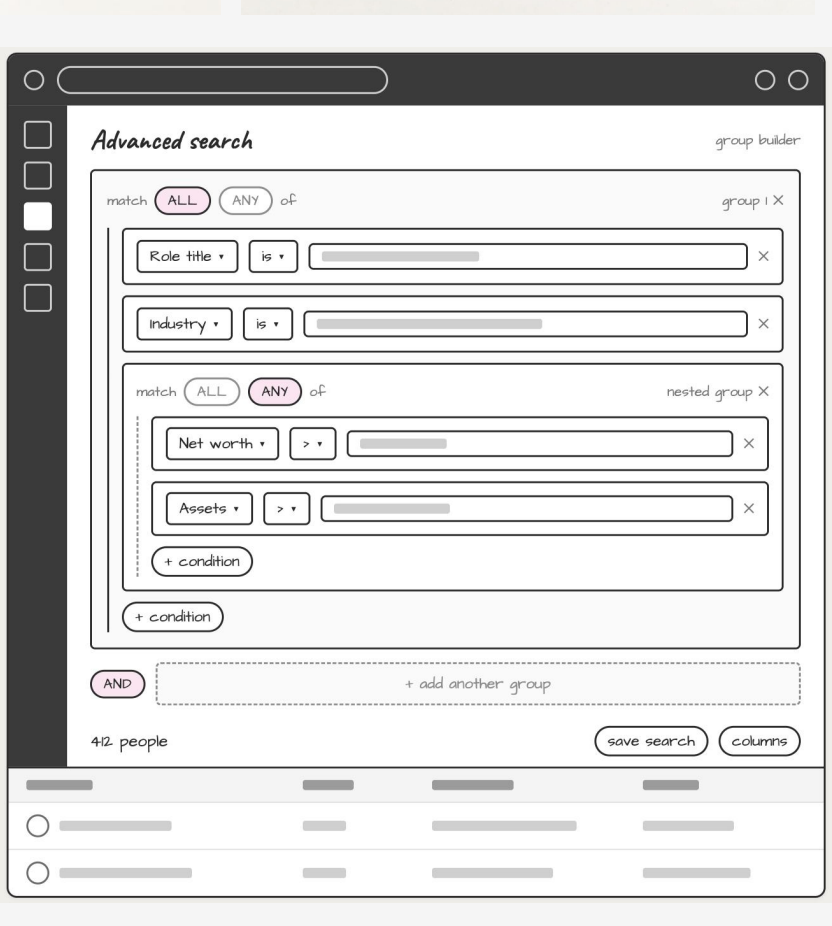


Existing advanced search without boolean logic

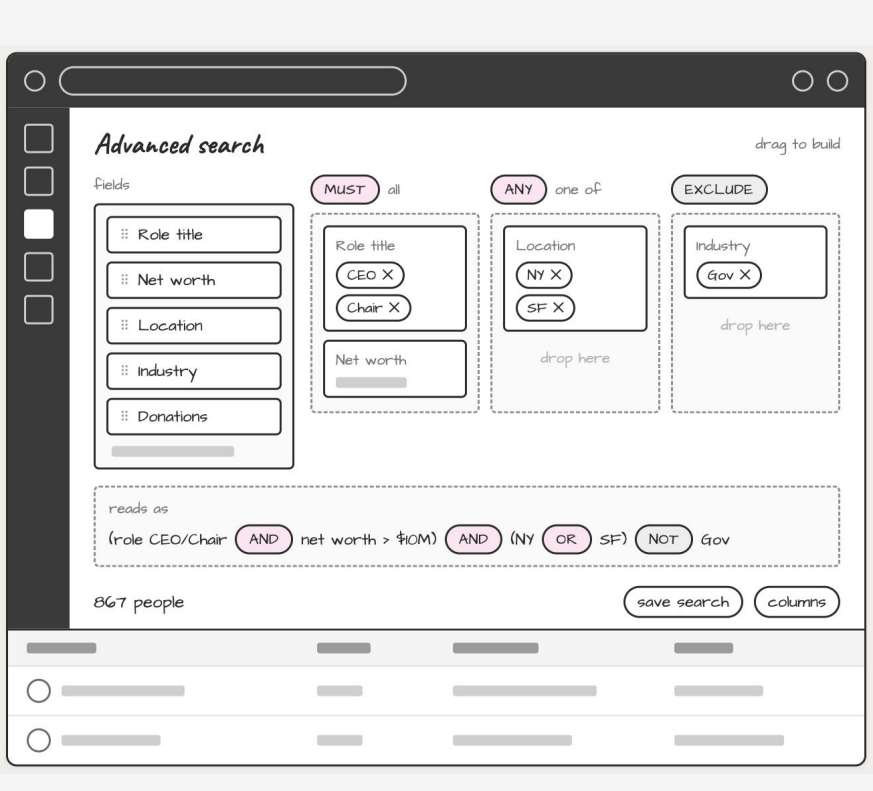




Inline operators - one flat list, operator lives between rows



Query groups - nested brackets, operator owned by the group

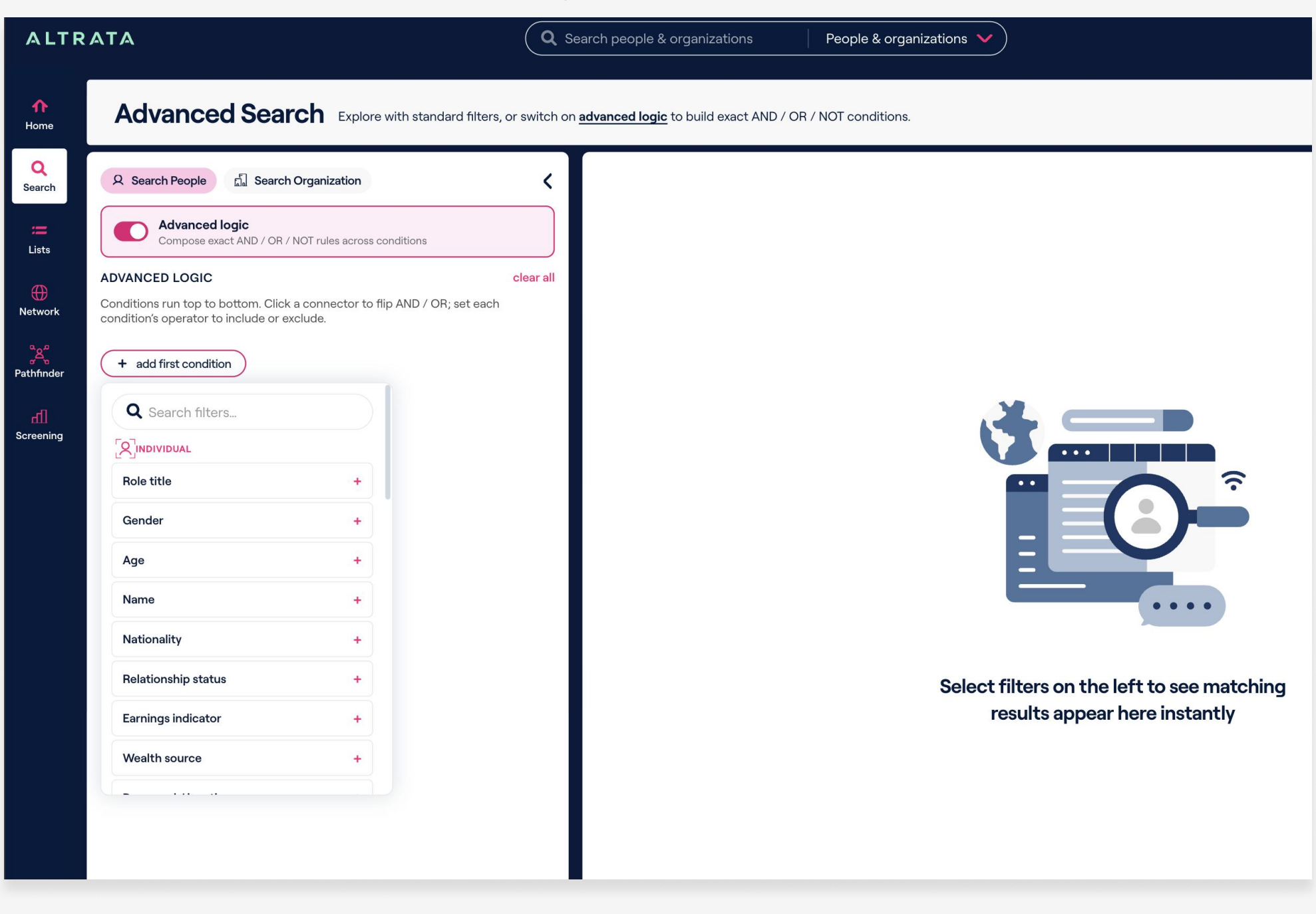


Buckets - drag fields into must / any / exclude columns

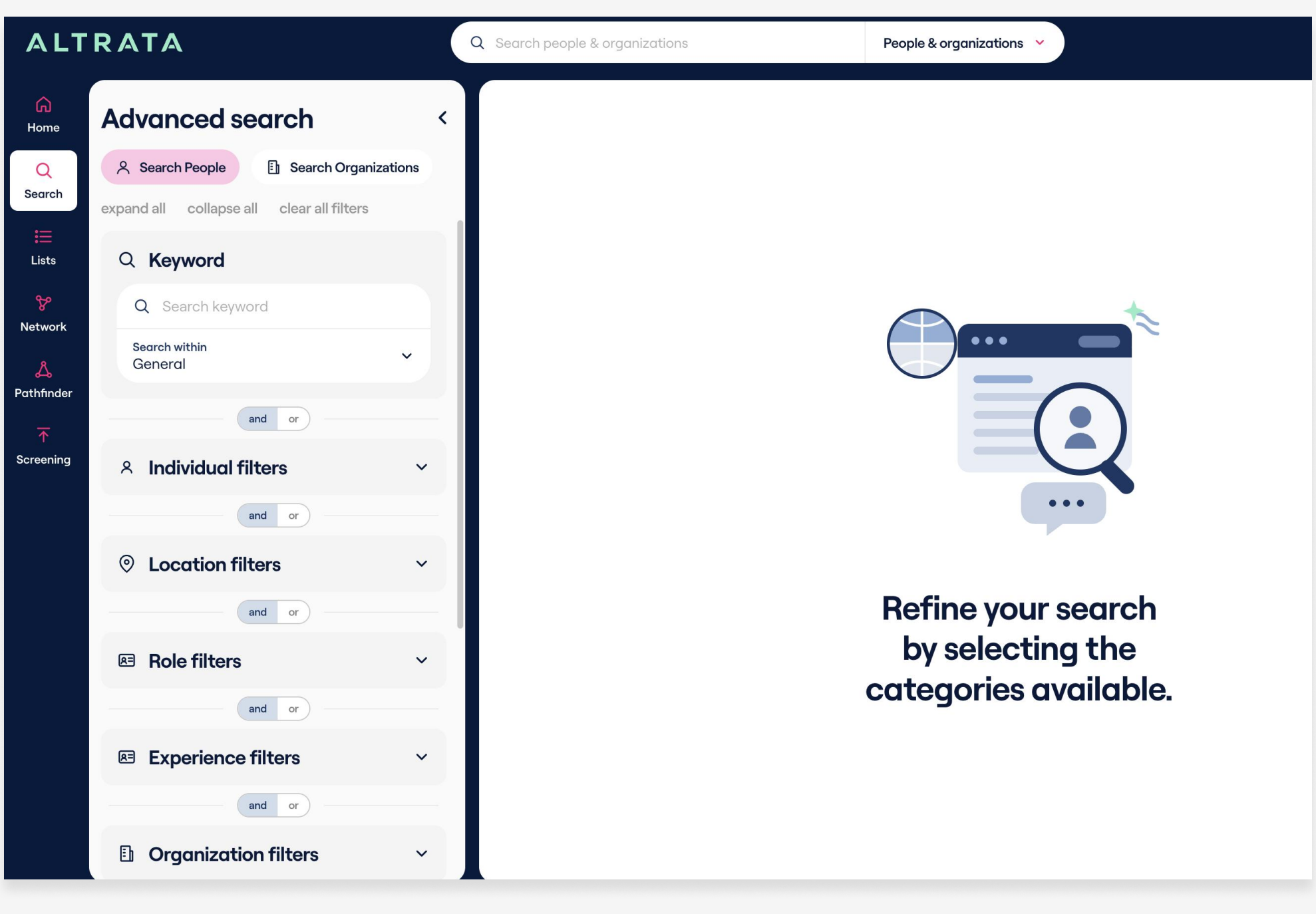
Several iterations later, the two briefs had resolved into **genuinely different concepts.** One was a new approach none of the legacy brands had, closer to how comparably complex products work elsewhere but tuned to Altrata. The other embedded boolean into the current structure, with all filters displayed at once.

The question was what users preferred, how much **complexity they'd tolerate,** and whether one **product could serve both or needed to let users choose.**
Every round of testing ahead was an attempt to answer that.

Concept A (mine) **assumes you think in rules, and gives you a blank slate to build one.**


ALTRATA
Search people & organizations
People & organizations
Home
Search
Lists
Network
Pathfinder
Screening
Advanced Search
Explore with standard filters, or switch on advanced logic to build exact AND / OR / NOT conditions.
Search People
Search Organization
Advanced logic
Compose exact AND / OR / NOT rules across conditions
ADVANCED LOGIC
clear all
Conditions run top to bottom. Click a connector to flip AND / OR; set each condition's operator to include or exclude.
+ add first condition
Search filters...
INDIVIDUAL
Role title
Gender
Age
Name
Nationality
Relationship status
Earnings indicator
Wealth source
Select filters on the left to see matching results appear here instantly

Concept B (other designer's) **assumes you think in filters, and fits boolean into the modules you already use.**



Design Toolkit
Prepping for Testing

The concepts were still low-fidelity and light on detail, so clients weren't the right audience yet. I proposed **internal product stakeholders as a first check:** people who could tell us quickly whether the two directions worked, aligned with strategy, and were worth taking further.

2	10	20 mins	1
Finalised concepts	Internal Stakeholders **(Data, Product, Dev)**	per session	week

We built **interactive prototypes with Claude.** 18 participants across two rounds in 5 weeks, clicking real interactions rather than static screens.

Expectation vs Reality
Round 1

Testing returned **a tie.**

we love Concept A! (5/5)

"Rule builders are the new age filters now." (Data Product Manager)

"I got something pretty complex in like a minute and a half, that's very helpful." (Account Manager)

"Having and/or idea on each filter makes it quite confusing for me. Whereas this makes it incredibly simple." (Product Director)

we love Concept B! (5/5)

"I like to see all the options available to me. That helps me make a decision." (Developer)

"I feel like it should just be baked in. It's just an extra step that I don't think I need to take." (Senior Product Mananger)

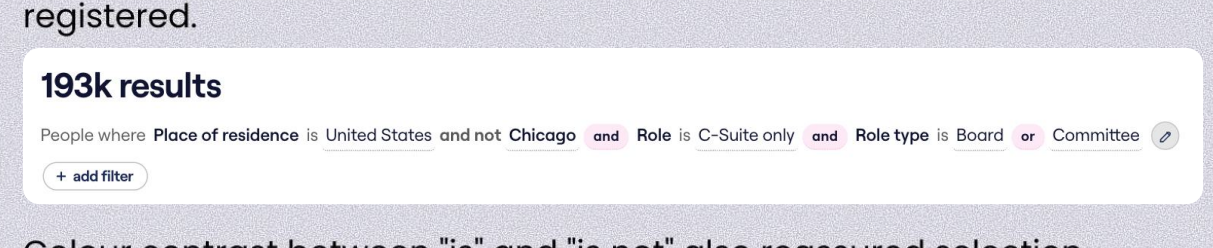
"It opens a completely new UI for us to build a query, and it was not very intuitive for me." (Product Manager)

Key Highlight.

A visible pattern emerged. Tech-savvy participants preferred the self-build option; less tech-savvy ones preferred it built in. **A preference split rather than a usability issue.**

Insights that fed into the design.

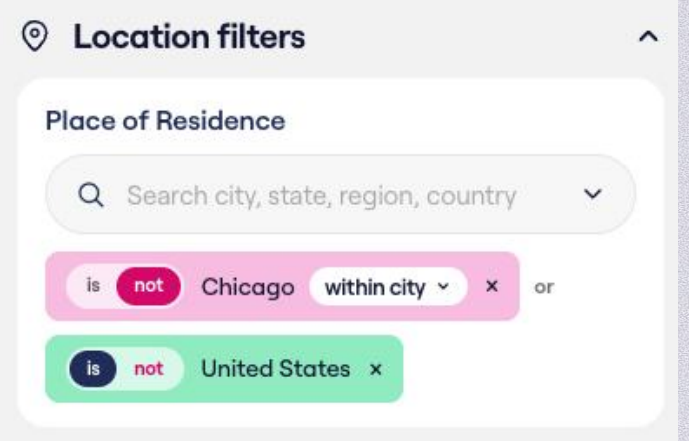
- The live query statement reassured people their filter selections had registered.



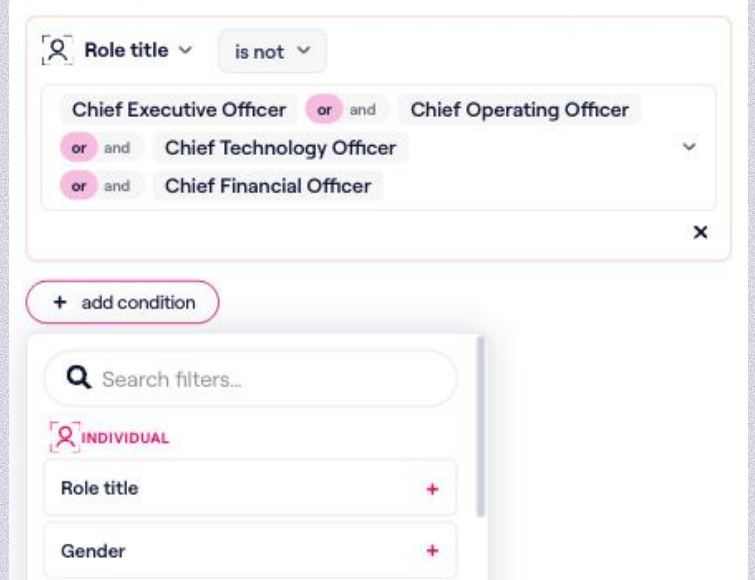
193k results

People where Place of residence is United States and not Chicago and Role is C-Suite only and Role type is Board or Committee

- Colour contrast between "is" and "is not" also reassured selection.

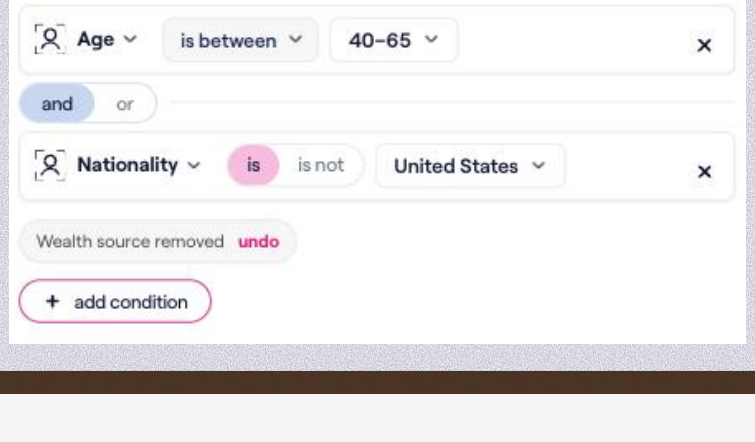


- Group multiple values of the same field together rather than stacking them separately.
  The UI automatically combine values of duplicate fields.
- Reduce the burden of knowing what sits behind each filter when the list isn't laid out.
  Searchable filters.



This was more like group ideation, and it gave us the detailing we needed!

- Provide undo for an accidentally removed rule.



but..

What was missing.

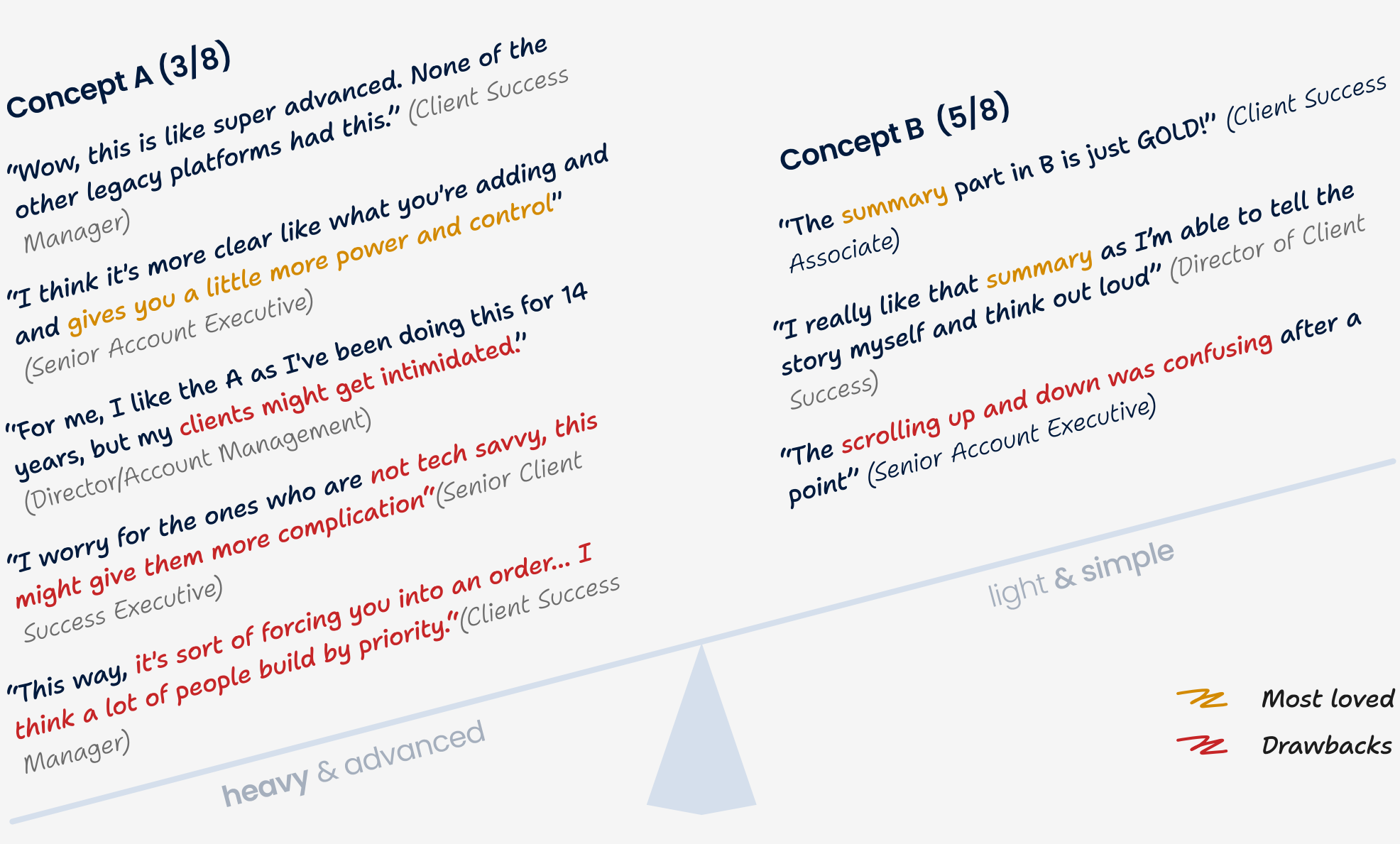
Internal stakeholders knew the product and gave us good enhancement ideas, but **no real use cases.** Useful for shaping the concepts, not for choosing between them.

A Better Proxy
Round 2

To fill that gap I proposed a closer proxy: Commercial and Customer Success, who spend the most time with clients. It also bought time to deepen the concepts before reaching real users.

2	8	30-40 mins	1
Updated concepts	**Commercial & CS**	per session	week

Round 2 gave us a lot of insight, alongside a pattern of bias. Close as they were to clients, their read was still second-hand.



Concept A (3/8)

"Wow, this is like super advanced. None of the other legacy platforms had this." (Client Success Manager)

"I think it's more clear like what you're adding and gives you a little more power and control" (Senior Account Executive)

"For me, I like the A as I've been doing this for 14 years, but my clients might get intimidated." (Director/Account Management)

"I worry for the ones who are not tech savvy, this might give them more complication" (Senior Client Success Executive)

"This way, it's sort of forcing you into an order... I think a lot of people build by priority." (Client Success Manager)

Concept B (5/8)

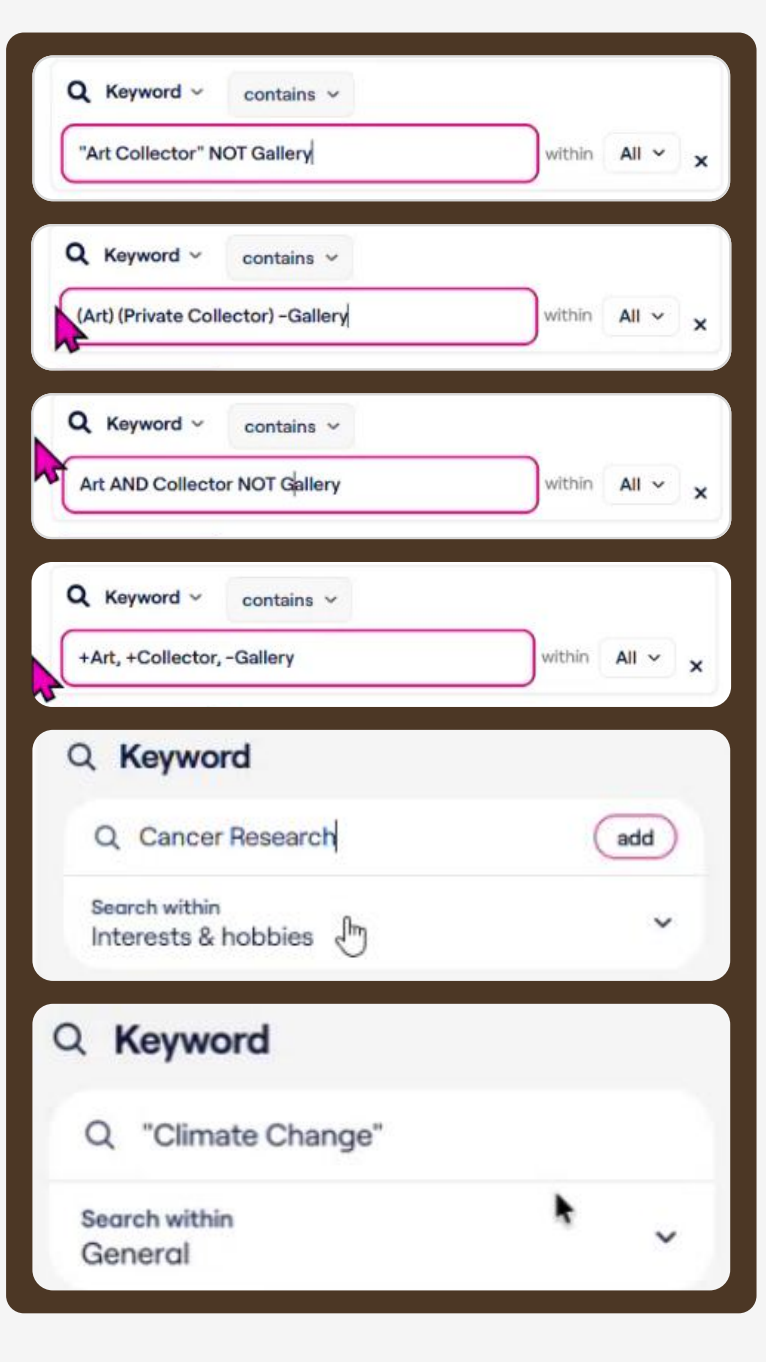
"The summary part in B is just GOLD!" (Client Success Associate)

"I really like that summary as I'm able to tell the story myself and think out loud" (Director of Client Success)

"The scrolling up and down was confusing after a point" (Senior Account Executive)

Key highlight & what AI couldn't see.

Five of eight participants, all experienced at training clients, first tried to type their **whole query into a single keyword field** using parentheses, quotation marks and AND/OR/NOT directly. Muscle memory, acted out silently.
No transcript captures that. So I directed the team to run a **manual pass on interactions, facial reactions, and physical movement** toward the screen.

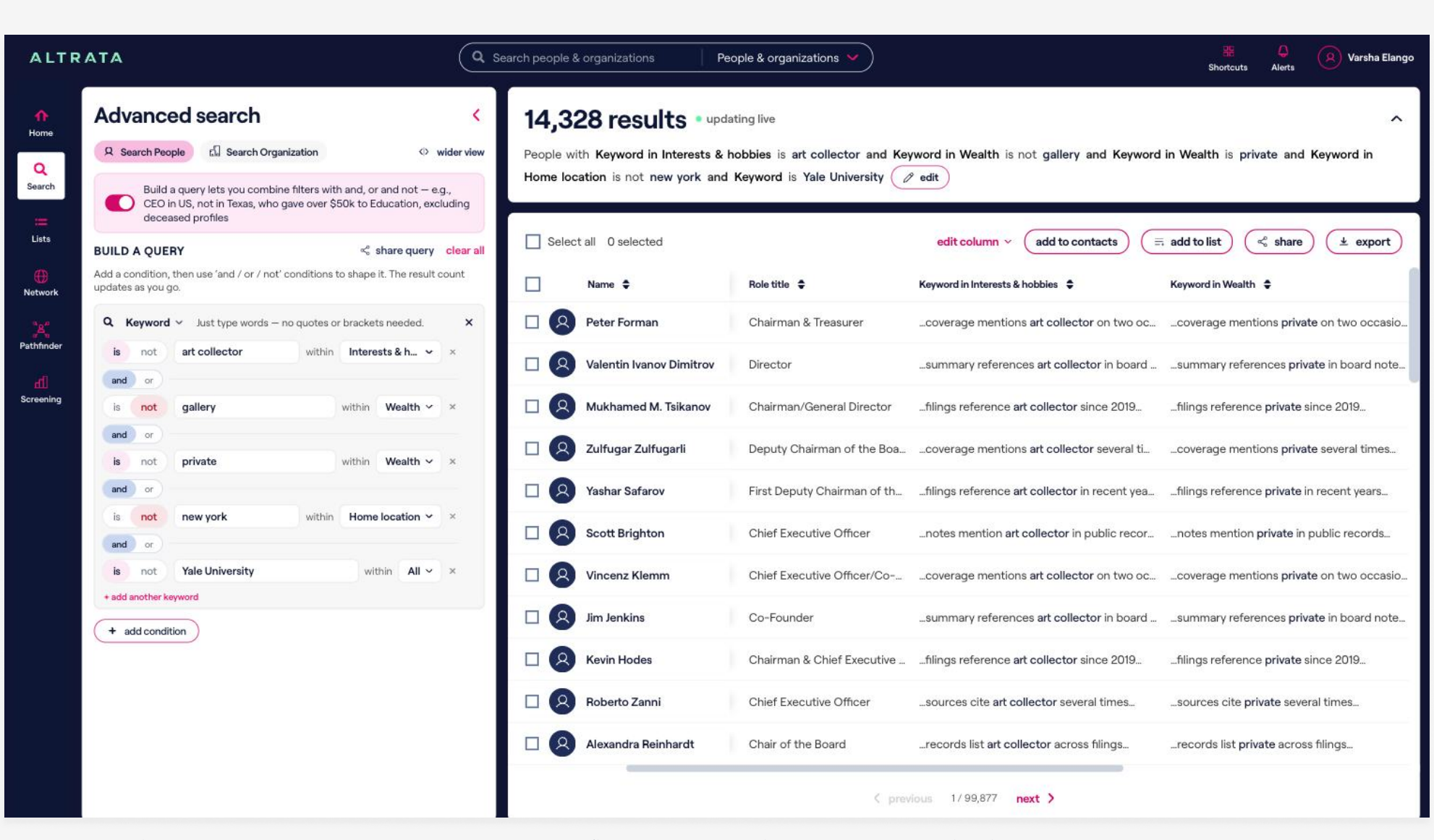

Keyword
contains
"Art Collector" NOT Gallery
(Art) (Private Collector) -Gallery
Art AND Collector NOT Gallery
+Art, +Collector, -Gallery
within
All
Cancer Research
add
Search within
Interests & hobbies
"Climate Change"
Search within
General

Director of Client Success leaning in.
The moment five of eight participants had, silently. No transcript records it.

Insights that fed into the design.

- On Concept A, most users searched by value rather than by field - **"CEO" rather than "Role title."** A mental model worth designing to.
- Make **keyword search boolean-capable in its own right,** since that's where people instinctively went first.
- The **readable summary** can extend **into exports,** so gift officers and managers not using the platform still see the criteria.
- A **clearer toggle** for what advanced logic will do.

Sharpened both concepts considerably.



14,328 results · updating live

People with Keyword in Interests & hobbies is art collector and Keyword in Wealth is not gallery and Keyword in Wealth is private and Keyword in Home location is not new york and Keyword is Yale University

Build a query lets you combine filters with and, or and not — e.g., CEO in US, not in Texas, who gave over $50k to Education, excluding deceased profiles

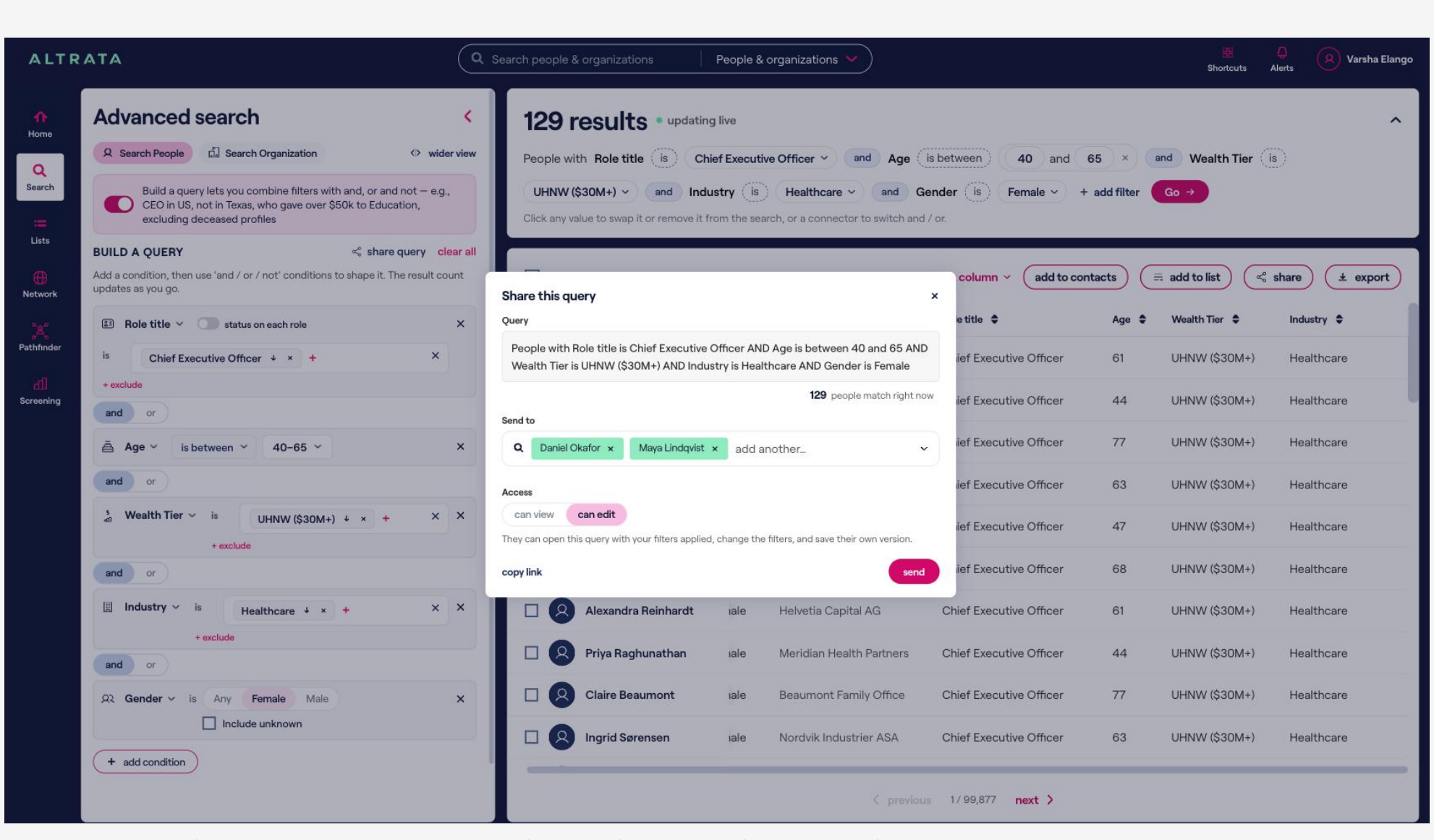
BUILD A QUERY

Add a condition, then use 'and / or / not' conditions to shape it. The result count updates as you go.

Keyword — Just type words — no quotes or brackets needed.

Name	Role title	Keyword in Interests & hobbies	Keyword in Wealth
Peter Forman	Chairman & Treasurer	...coverage mentions art collector on two oc...	...coverage mentions private on two occasio...
Valentin Ivanov Dimitrov	Director	...summary references art collector in board ...	...summary references private in board note...
Mukhamed M. Tsikanov	Chairman/General Director	...filings reference art collector since 2019...	...filings reference private since 2019...
Zulfugar Zulfugarli	Deputy Chairman of the Boa...	...coverage mentions art collector several ti...	...coverage mentions private several times...
Yashar Safarov	First Deputy Chairman of th...	...filings reference art collector in recent yea...	...filings reference private in recent years...
Scott Brighton	Chief Executive Officer	...notes mention art collector in public recor...	...notes mention private in public records...
Vincenz Klemm	Chief Executive Officer/Co-...	...coverage mentions art collector on two oc...	...coverage mentions private on two occasio...
Jim Jenkins	Co-Founder	...summary references art collector in board ...	...summary references private in board note...
Kevin Hodes	Chairman & Chief Executive ...	...filings reference art collector since 2019...	...filings reference private since 2019...
Roberto Zanni	Chief Executive Officer	...sources cite art collector several times...	...sources cite private several times...
Alexandra Reinhardt	Chair of the Board	...records list art collector across filings...	...records list private across filings...

Concept A, with keyword search now boolean across all filters. The same improvement carried into Concept B.



129 results · updating live

People with Role title is Chief Executive Officer and Age is between 40 and 65 and Wealth Tier is UHNW ($30M+) and Industry is Healthcare and Gender is Female

Click any value to swap it or remove it from the search, or a connector to switch and / or.

Share this query

Query: People with Role title is Chief Executive Officer AND Age is between 40 and 65 AND Wealth Tier is UHNW ($30M+) AND Industry is Healthcare AND Gender is Female

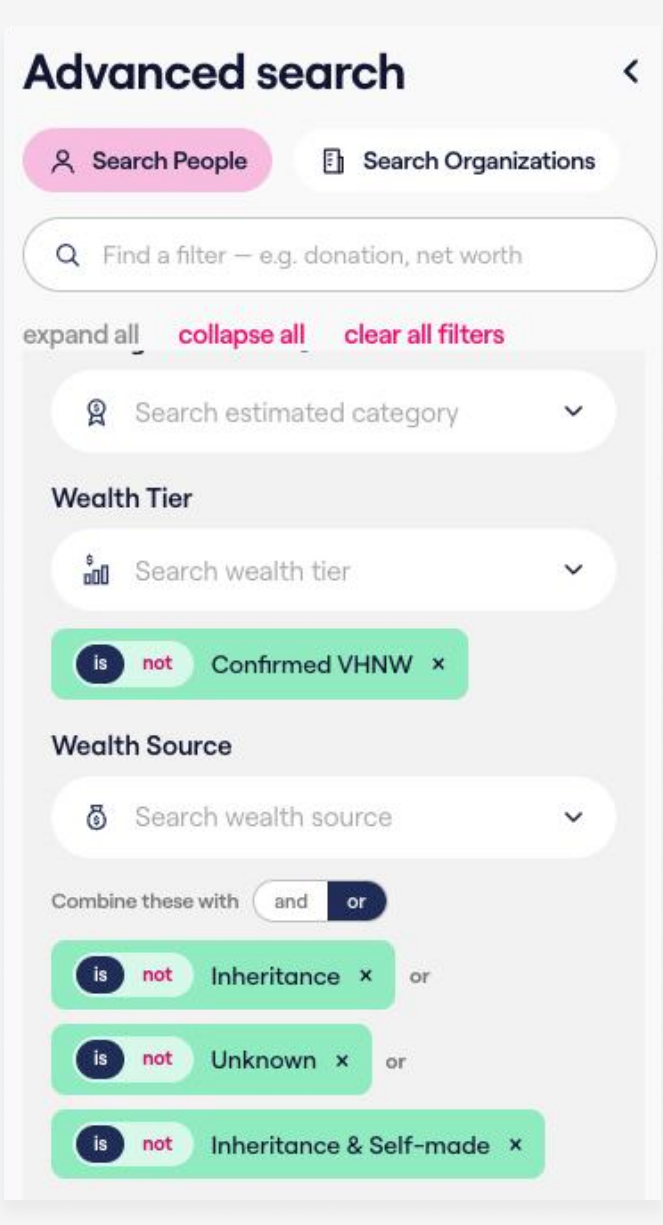
129 people match right now

Send to: Daniel Okafor, Maya Lindqvist

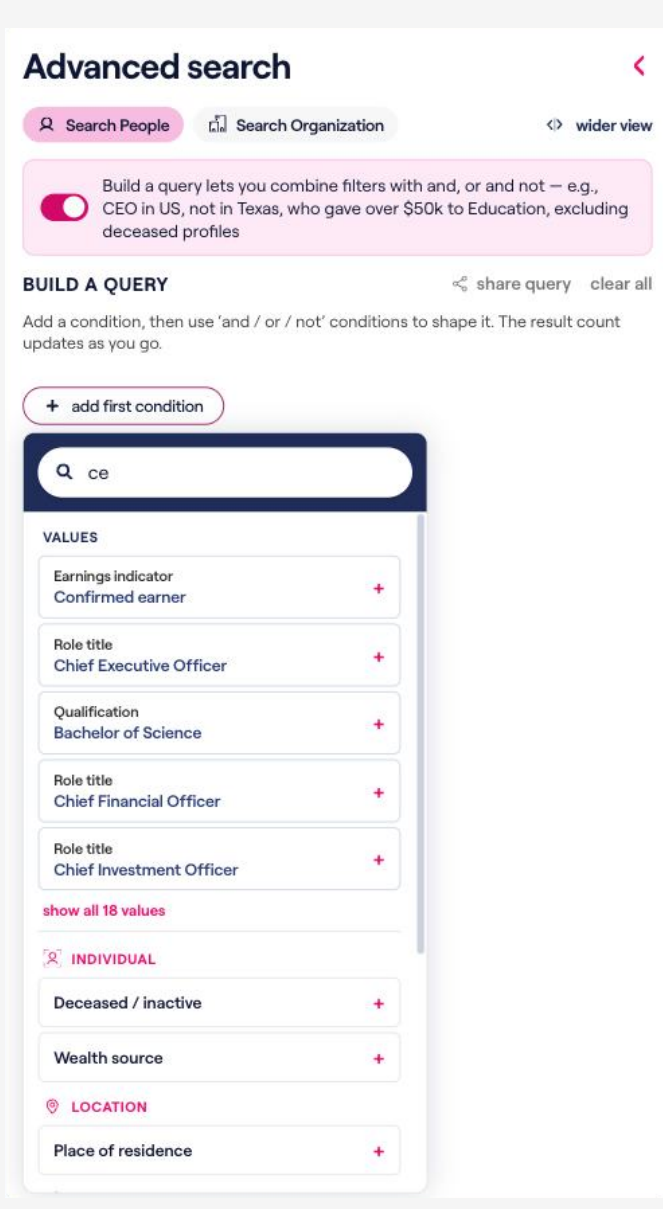
Access: can view / can edit

They can open this query with your filters applied, change the filters, and save their own version.

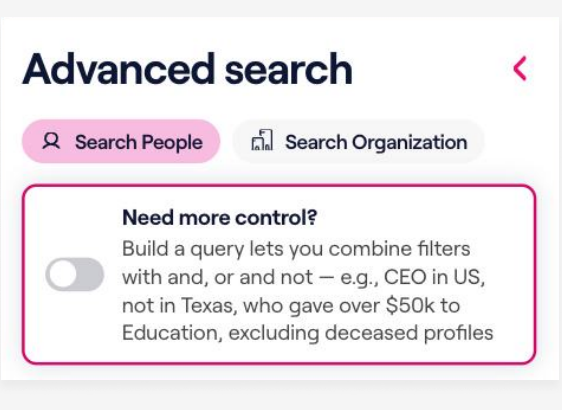
Concept A, extending the search summary export into sharing an ongoing search with teammates.



Concept B hides the and/or toggle until more than one option is selected. Moving it from the filter title to the selections applies the law of proximity.



Concept A, allowing search by values while adding conditions.


Advanced search
Search People
Search Organization
Need more control?
Build a query lets you combine filters with and, or and not — e.g., CEO in US, not in Texas, who gave over $50k to Education, excluding deceased profiles

Switching from current filters into Concept A, with a clearer explanation and a worked example.

but...

Growing pattern.

- **Technical confidence** shaped preference here too, but with more to it. Half the participants wanted Concept A for themselves and Concept B for their clients, assuming from past experience that A would need more hand-holding. That judgment was about people who weren't in the room.
- Concept A was more targeted, built for power boolean users. B's summary was great, but, **scrolling through filters made it easy to get lost**, the same problem clients already had with the existing list.
- **Almost everyone wanted parts of both,** neither one whole. That matched our instinct, though it needed real users to confirm.

and...

What should be improved.

- We showed Concept A first to some participants and B first to others, and saw that whichever came first gave people time to **warm to boolean before the second.** We needed to **reduce that influence** in the next round.
- We asked people to think of a complex query live in the session, which was difficult to do on the spot. A heads-up to **prepare one beforehand** would have helped.

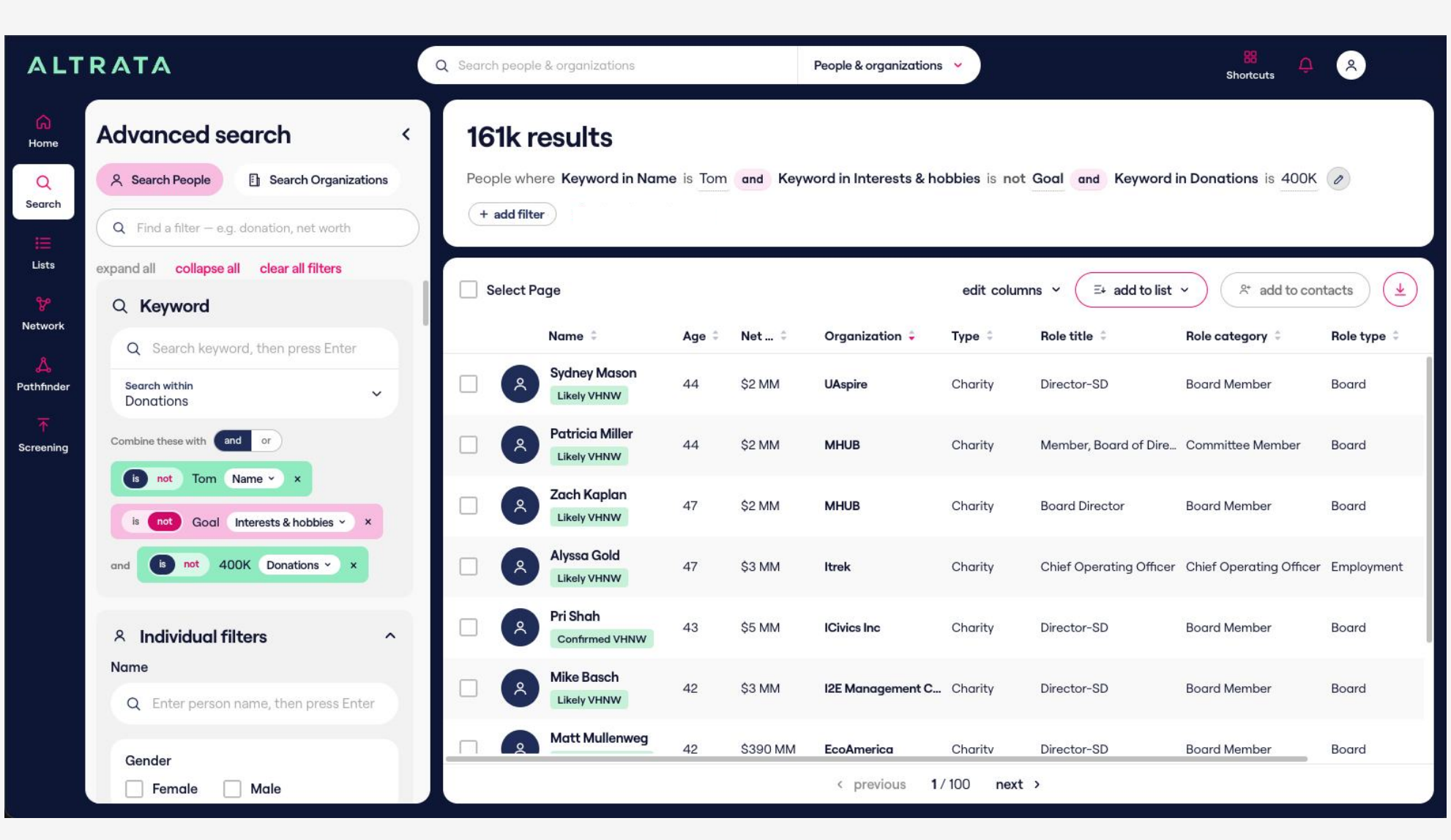
The call I made
Round 3

To **tackle concept bias, I proposed an A/B split** for round 3, tracking discoverability, onboarding and feature adoption unaided rather than hand-held.
In my experience across enterprise products, **client time is the scarcest resource.** What comes back from commercial is consistently "clients are busy," "we can't bother them now,". Round 3 didn't run, due to business constraints.

Two rounds across two populations had already settled the thing that mattered: **people go to keyword search first**, and the **readable statement works for everyone who sees it**. What they hadn't settled was whether Concept A's learning curve is a real barrier or just an unfamiliar one, and five users a side wouldn't have answered that fully.
So I made the call on what we had.

What shipped

The first release **leads with keyword search**, with Concept B's subtler route into boolean and the **readable statement throughout.** It's where the behaviour already was, it was quicker to build, and usage will answer the question testing couldn't.
It's live, and we're tracking adoption now.

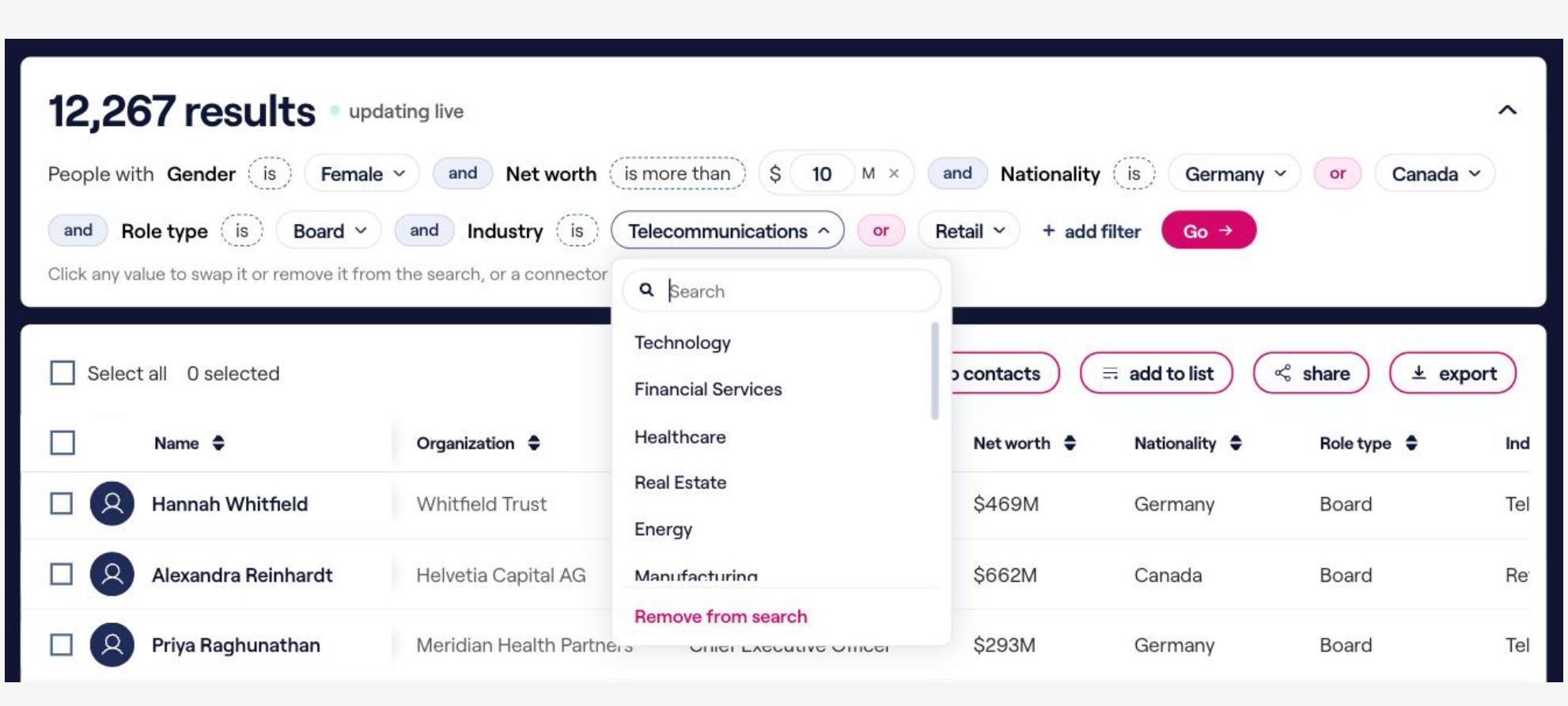


161k results

People where Keyword in Name is Tom and Keyword in Interests & hobbies is not Goal and Keyword in Donations is 400K

Name	Age	Net ...	Organization	Type	Role title	Role category	Role type
Sydney Mason Likely VHNW	44	$2 MM	UAspire	Charity	Director-SD	Board Member	Board
Patricia Miller Likely VHNW	44	$2 MM	MHUB	Charity	Member, Board of Dire...	Committee Member	Board
Zach Kaplan Likely VHNW	47	$2 MM	MHUB	Charity	Board Director	Board Member	Board
Alyssa Gold Likely VHNW	47	$3 MM	Itrek	Charity	Chief Operating Officer	Chief Operating Officer	Employment
Pri Shah Confirmed VHNW	43	$5 MM	ICivics Inc	Charity	Director-SD	Board Member	Board
Mike Basch Likely VHNW	42	$3 MM	I2E Management C...	Charity	Director-SD	Board Member	Board
Matt Mullenweg	42	$390 MM	EcoAmerica	Charity	Director-SD	Board Member	Board

Keyword search, now sitting inside the existing advanced search with boolean across all filters.



12,267 results · updating live

People with Gender is Female and Net worth is more than $ 10 M and Nationality is Germany or Canada and Role type is Board and Industry is Telecommunications or Retail

Click any value to swap it or remove it from the search, or a connector

Allowing ability to edit from the query summary.